

Day Hike Plan: Naches Peak Loop

Mount Rainier area, east side off Highway 410. A short loop I keep coming back to when I need a day out of the lab and away from the laptop. Not a big objective, just trail under my feet and time to think. Borrowing Marisol's car again, filling the tank.

The basics

- Trail: Naches Peak Loop, roughly 3.5 miles, gentle climb, easy to do clockwise for the Rainier views in the back half.
- When: a clear fall Saturday, target a late October 2026 weekend after the fieldwork crunch. Go early, the small lot fills by mid morning.
- Pass: Northwest Forest day pass on the dash, the one I already keep in the glovebox.

Before I go

- Check the road and trail status and the mountain forecast the night before. Conditions flip fast up there and early snow is a real thing by late October.
- Tell Mom the rough plan and when to expect a text. No signal for long stretches, that is half the point.
- Charge the phone, download the map offline, do not trust the bars at the pass.

The pack (the usual REI pile)

- Rain shell and the good wool layers, it is colder at elevation than the car says.
- The dented camp stove and the thermos, trail coffee is non negotiable.
- Water, plus the filter just in case. Apples and almond butter, the emergency RXBARs at the bottom of the bag.
- Headlamp, small first aid kit, the field notebook even though this one is not work.

Why I bother

Half my better thesis ideas show up around the second mile, somewhere past the first meadow. The loop is short enough to do slow, sit at the tarns, watch the light move on the mountain, and still be home to call Kai by evening. Relaxed pace, no summit pressure, the whole appeal is the quiet.